Chapter Four

War!

"I had faith in Israel before it was established, I have faith in it now."

—US President Harry S. Truman

The Arab plan was relatively simple: Iraqi forces would attack the Jezreel Valley while the Arab Legion would take Ramallah and Nablus and link with the Egyptian and Syrian armies at the city of Hebron. The combined force would then advance toward Haifa and Tel Aviv. Few of the Arab military commanders believed that the war would last more than two weeks, and most outside observers (unaware, like the Arab League, of the secret deals that were allowing Israel to arm its forces) also assumed that the IDF would be quickly defeated.

One of the first battles fought between the IDF and forces of the Egyptian Army quickly proved that the outcome of this conflict would not be as simple as most people had assumed. On May 15, the Egyptians invaded from the south, attacking Israeli settlements at Nirim and Kfar Darom. Both attacks were driven off by the lightly armed defenders. On May 19, a force of around 2,500 Egyptian troops supported by armored vehicles, artillery, and aircraft launched a major attack on another settlement at Yad Mordechai. The defenders of this settlement amounted to little more than 100 troops armed with rifles and a single light machine gun. Somehow, they were able to hold off repeated Egyptian attacks over the course of five days and cause heavy casualties in the Egyptian force.

Another Egyptian attack drove north into what is today the Gaza Strip, where they attacked more Jewish settlements. Again, the defenders were relentless, and the Egyptians were held for several days and suffered heavy casualties. These relatively small-scale actions were not decisive in themselves, but they did cause a reappraisal on the Egyptian side as to how quickly the war could be